

“They came upon us crying and shouting, to the very point of our bayonets”

BRITISH OFFICER CAPTAIN THOMAS POCOCKE, DESCRIBING THE FRENCH AT VIMIERO, 1808

of all able-bodied men under 25. It was an appeal for what would later be called “total war”: the rest of the population was to devote itself to supporting the war effort. The citizen-soldiers were expected to fight out of devotion to the nation and the revolution – rather than through fear of the lash and the gallows – and the officer ranks, previously monopolized by the aristocracy, were opened up to competent soldiers of all social backgrounds.

THE GRANDE ARMÉE

The new political climate brought about by the French Revolution transformed France into an expansionist power. Napoleon Bonaparte established himself as the country’s most popular general and then became, in effect, a military

dictator. By 1805, he had built the “Grande Armée”, an army divided into six all-arms corps, each capable of independent manoeuvre. Freed from reliance on a supply train by living off the land, Napoleon moved his army at speed to bring the enemy to battle and destroy them. On the battlefield he emphasized the attack: musket-armed infantry advanced in dense columns preceded by swarms of skirmishers, and the cuirassiers (armoured heavy cavalry) mounted massed charges. Gunners deployed cannon aggressively – Napoleon regarded the artillery as potential battle-winners, rather than a mere support to infantry and cavalry.

France’s enemies took time to adjust to this new scale and dynamism, but over time they mobilized resources in their own version of total war. In Spain from 1808, and later, in Russia in 1812, France was defeated by relentless resistance, in the form of guerrilla warfare and pitched battles. At Leipzig in 1813, in the largest battle Europe had ever seen, Napoleon commanded an army of 200,000 men, but was outnumbered by two-to-one. With mass conscription and ever-improving weapons, this was the era that saw European societies begin a path to militarization – one that would bear bitter fruit in the world wars of the 20th century.



▲ THE CONGREVE ROCKET

Inspired by the rocket artillery of the Indian kingdom of Mysore, the British Congreve rocket was propelled by black powder and had an explosive warhead.

▼ THE BATTLE OF VALMY

The first battle of the French Revolutionary Wars, fought in September 1792, was a victory for French artillery defending the heights of Valmy.

